

Steal your competitors' best keywords

Legally. ASO from competitor research, 1-star reviews and real comments, with parallel AI chats

THE SHORT ANSWER

Your competitors already paid to learn which words and screenshots work. Their listings, their 1-star reviews and the comments under their videos tell you what to rank for and what to promise.

Research 5 sources at once in 5 AI chats with the same prompt, merge them in a 6th, then **check every number in a real tool before you trust it.**

Keywords win the visit. Your first screenshot, icon and rating win the install. So this guide does both: what to rank for, and what to show when people land.

The store rules you're working with

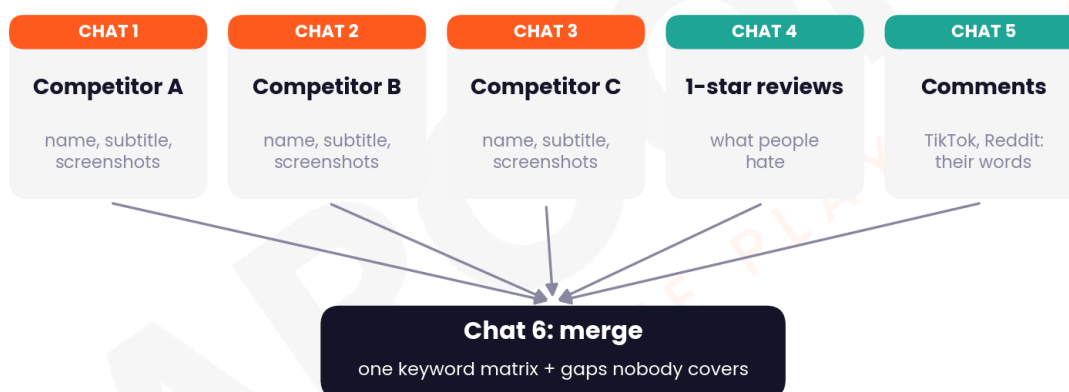
	APP STORE	GOOGLE PLAY
Strongest slot	App name (30 characters)	Title (30 characters)
Second slot	Subtitle (30)	Short description (80)
Hidden keywords	Keyword field (100). Commas, no spaces	None. Play reads the whole listing
Description	Not used for ranking. It's for converting	Used for ranking. Repeat your main keyword 2 or 3 times, naturally
Screenshots	Caption text is read and indexed since June 2025	Not indexed, but they decide the install

- **On Apple, never repeat a word** across name, subtitle and keyword field. Apple combines them, so a repeat wastes space
- **Skip "app", your brand and category names** in the keyword field. Apple handles plurals, so you only need one form
- **Never use a competitor's brand name** anywhere. Both stores reject it

Step 1. Pick 3 competitors that are winning

Not the giants. Apps a bit bigger than you, with recent reviews and signs of growth. The Vol 01 checks work here too: steady new reviews, ads still running, updates in the last few months.

Step 2. Research 5 sources in 5 parallel chats



Same prompt in every research chat, so the outputs line up. Then you check the numbers in real tools.

Open 5 separate AI chats. Paste each one its own source: a competitor's listing text and screenshots, a batch of 1-star reviews, or comments copied from TikTok and Reddit posts about the problem. Use the same prompt in each, so the answers come back in the same shape and are easy to merge.

PROMPT FOR CHATS 1 TO 5

You are an ASO analyst. Here is [source: competitor listing / 1-star reviews / social comments]. Extract:

- 1) Every keyword and phrase a user might search, in their words
- 2) The top 3 benefits promised, and how they're worded
- 3) Complaints or unmet needs, grouped, with how often they appear
- 4) What the first 2 screenshots say, if given

Output as tables. Don't invent search volumes. Mark any guess as [est.].

PROMPT FOR CHAT 6: MERGE

Here are 5 research outputs. Merge them into one keyword matrix: keyword, relevance to my app ([describe it]), where it came from, placement (name / subtitle / keyword field / short description). Then list the gaps: needs that users mention but no competitor's listing promises.

THE GOLD IS IN THE GAPS

When 1-star reviews keep saying "too many ads", "doesn't work offline" or "no Hindi", and no competitor's listing promises the fix, that's your subtitle and your first screenshot. You're not just ranking for their words. You're promising what they don't deliver.

Step 3. Check the numbers in real tools

AI can pull words out of text. It can't see search volume. Before a keyword goes in your name or subtitle, check it:

SOURCE	WHAT IT GIVES YOU	COST
Your own consoles	App Store Connect and Play Console search terms: what people already type to find you	Free
Apple Ads popularity	A 5 to 100 demand score for each keyword on iOS	Free with an Apple Ads account

SOURCE	WHAT IT GIVES YOU	COST
Store autocomplete	Type a word in the store search. What appears first is searched more	Free
Paid ASO tools	Sensor Tower, AppTweak, AppFigures and others: estimates and competitor data	Paid, free trials exist

For a new or small app, **pick keywords you can actually rank for** over big ones. "Habit tracker" is a war. "Habit tracker with reminders for students" can be yours in weeks.

Step 4. Write the listing

TEMPLATE WITH CHARACTER COUNTS

App Name (30): Brand: Main Keyword (NN/30)
 Subtitle (30): Second keyword + benefit (NN/30)
 Keywords (100): word,word,word (no repeats) (NN/100)

Play Title (30): Brand - Main Keyword
 Short description (80): Main keyword + the gap you fill

Step 5. Screenshots that win the install

- **The first screenshot does most of the work.** One big benefit, starting with a verb: TRACK, SAVE, LEARN
- **Say what the user gets, not the feature name.** "Stop scrolling at night" beats "Screen time blocker"
- **Add social proof** if you have it: "20,000+ users" on the first screenshot
- **Put a real keyword in each caption** on iOS, since captions are indexed
- **Show the fix for the gap** you found in the 1-star reviews, early in the set
- **No empty screens, debug text or login screens.** Clean status bar, one consistent style

Step 6. Localise, don't translate

Every language gets its own keyword research, not a translation of your English keywords. People in Germany or Brazil search with their own words. Most indie devs skip this, which is exactly why it works.

Then test, patiently

Apple's Product Page Optimization tests screenshots, icon and video. Google's Store Listing Experiments test almost everything. Run each test at least 14 days, and longer for small apps. **Calling a winner on day 5 is the most common mistake.**

MY REAL STORY

- [SnapPDF](#) was ranking for nothing in month 1, invisible under Adobe Scan and CamScanner
- Pulled the top 10 PDF scanner apps into AppTweak, exported their keyword set, sorted by low difficulty high volume
- Found 14 long tail keywords they ranked for that I did not: scan to pdf free, document scanner no ads, pdf editor offline
- Rewrote my title, subtitle and description around those 14, kept keyword density natural
- 3 weeks later I ranked top 20 for 9 of them, organic installs jumped from 4 a day to 60
- Lesson is competitors already paid to find the keywords that work, do not guess, just steal their homework

Checklist

- ☐ 3 winning competitors picked, a bit bigger than me
- ☐ 5 research chats run with the same prompt, merged in a 6th
- ☐ Gaps found: needs users mention that nobody promises
- ☐ Top keywords checked in my consoles, Apple Ads or a paid tool

- ❑ No repeated words across Apple name, subtitle and keywords
- ❑ First screenshot: one benefit, a verb, social proof
- ❑ At least one extra language with its own keyword research

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